

PARADIGM SHIFT
Jan Suraaj chief Prashant Kishor addresses supporters in Bhojpur, Jul. 2

PTI

The SWOT Analysis

STRENGTHS: Freshness, charisma, media traction,; absence of baggage

WEAKNESSES: Organisational fragility; limited booth presence; overdependence on PK's personality

OPPORTUNITIES: Act as spoiler in closely fought seats; push national parties to re-evaluate caste calculus; become the guiding light for the disillusioned youth

THREATS: Being reduced to becoming fringe spoilers post-election; loss of credibility if alliances shift opportunistically

Jan Suraaj: Eyeing the Big Prize

Political strategist Prashant Kishor, or PK, who once orchestrated victories for others—Modi in 2014, Nitish in 2015, Mamata in 2021—is now seeking one for his own party. The Jan Suraaj is barely a year old, but carries the swagger of a start-up. A true disruptor, PK's campaign is bold and indifferent to political correctness: promising to replace caste with competence, superstition with data.

Repealing the liquor ban; establishing a Netarhat-style superachiever school in every block, while enabling poor children to immediately attend private schools in parallel; concrete doable steps to stem distress migration... PK proposes a mix of these at every rally, emphasising local governance and a reset of Bihar's self-image. The electoral playbook also includes proportional social representation and a candidate list to mirror community population in the specified seat. "On November 14, the day of counting," PK has declared, "we will witness the beginning of the end of Bihar's decay. It is the duty of Bihar's people to, for once, put aside caste and religion, temple–mosque and other petty issues, and vote to end distress migration and to secure better education and employment for their children."

Prashant Kishor is targeting the 25 per cent electors who did not vote for either alliance. He is also bursting NDA's *sushasan* narrative with corruption allegations

Jan Suraaj is targeting the 25 per cent "unclaimed" electorate—the eligible voters who in 2020 either abstained or did not line up behind the two dominant alliances. If he persuades even a quarter of those non-aligned voters to back Jan Suraaj, it could affect the result in many multi-corner seats. Alongside, he is also hoping to wean away some of the BJP's forward caste vote by positioning Jan Suraaj as a governance-first, delivery-oriented alternative. PK's other play has been to level dramatic, public allegations against several NDA leaders, including sitting ministers, muddying the latter's narrative of running a relatively clean government in Bihar. He has not spared the MGB either, decrying its alleged lack of meritocracy, and calling Tejashwi a dynast.

Despite PK's drive, Dr N.K. Choudhary, retired professor of economics and an independent commentator, expects the election to be a straight contest between the two big alliances. "Prashant Kishor lacks what the other two possess: a firmly established and committed vote base," Choudhary points out. "His promises on employment and education are certainly appealing and have drawn some disillusioned voters towards him. But, as I see it, the principal battle will be between the BJP and the RJD, with Nitish and the Congress playing supporting roles. Kishor can contribute in the defeat of many candidates." Bihar is likely to be a humdinger of a poll battle. In a state where almost one-fourth seats were decided by vote margins under 5,000 in 2020, every whisper, every promise and every rupee could make a difference. At the start of the race, it is still anyone's bet. ■